terrorism gained prominence, the surreptitious but palpable presence of Al Qaeda in a nuclear state with a desire to have a nuclear weapon further triggered the fear. However, instead of seriously deliberating over how and from where it could get hold of a nuclear bomb or the enriched uranium, the flurry of statements, issued by different quarters, stemming from crescendoing terrorist activity, created further hype.

Seymour Hersh wrote that the principal fear was that extremists inside the Pakistani military might stage a coup, take control of some nuclear assets or even divert a warhead. He added that although Pakistan ensured strict safeguards as the warheads and their triggers were stored separately from each other, and from their delivery devices, it enhanced the vulnerability during shipment and reassembly. This apprehension was based on contradictory logic as the strict safeguards were termed vulnerable, without actually going through the SOPs.

Shaun Gregory, director of the Pakistan Security Unit at the University of Bradford, UK, also stated, 'A frontal assault on nuclear weapons storage facilities, which are the most robustly defended elements of Pakistan's nuclear weapons cycle, is no longer an implausible event.' Shaun probably had lesser knowledge than Hersh about the storage system of nuclear weapons in Pakistan.

The *Daily Telegraph* of London reported that Pakistani Professor Pervez Hoodbhoy had stated that there was evidence that the Pakistan Army had been infiltrated by 'extremist elements'. As he stated, 'We have reason to worry because the most secure installations, bases, and headquarters of the military have been successfully attacked by Islamic militants who have sympathisers within the military.'

A retired Major General of the Pakistan Army termed it a wild guess.[8] He emphasised that the Pakistan Army was not 'so penetrated by extremists' that any of its officers would think of stealing the bomb. Doubtlessly, there must be some sympathisers of religious extremists, but the discipline in the Pakistan Army was par excellence. He remarked that there was not a single known precedent that any serving soldier defected and joined hands with the terrorists.

Similarly, there was no report that even a gun was stolen from the Pakistan Army to be used by the insurgents or ever recovered from them. Secondly, the nuclear arsenal was so well guarded that it could not fall in the hands of a couple of or even a batch of determined thieves. The notion of influence of radical Islamist ideology on Pakistan Army officers